Class 7 Social Science – Chapter 7

The Gupta Era: An Age of Tireless Creativity

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इस अध्याय की PDF के पृष्ठ 145–166 के आधार पर सभी मुख्य विषयों के प्रश्न-उत्तर, पाठ के Think About It और Let's Explore प्रश्नों के नमूना उत्तर तथा अंत के सभी अभ्यास प्रश्न सरल अंग्रेजी में दिए गए हैं। उत्तर कक्षा 7 के विद्यार्थियों के लिए परीक्षा की तैयारी में उपयोगी हैं।

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2. The Rise of the Gupta Empire

Q1. Who were the Guptas?

Answer: The Guptas were a powerful ruling dynasty of ancient India. They established an empire that flourished from the 3rd to the 6th century CE. Their capital was Pataliputra, present-day Patna.

Q2. When did the Gupta Empire become powerful?

Answer: The Gupta dynasty rose to power from the 3rd century CE. The empire became especially powerful under rulers such as Chandragupta I, Samudragupta and Chandragupta II.

Q3. Why is the Gupta period called the “Classical Age” of Indian history?

Answer: The Gupta period is sometimes called the Classical Age because art, architecture, literature, mathematics, astronomy and medicine made important progress during this time. A period of peace and stability helped scholars and artists work and create new things.

Q4. What was the capital of the Gupta Empire?

Answer: Pataliputra, present-day Patna in Bihar, was the capital of the Gupta Empire.

Q5. Which areas did the Gupta Empire cover at its height?

Answer: At its height, the Gupta Empire covered much of northern and western India and parts of central and eastern India.

Q6. What helped the Guptas build a powerful empire?

Answer: They used military campaigns, diplomacy, matrimonial alliances and land grants. They also received tribute from some rulers who accepted Gupta supremacy.

Q7. What is a matrimonial alliance?

Answer: A matrimonial alliance is a relationship between royal families formed through marriage. It helped rulers build friendly relations and strengthen their political power.

3. Chandragupta I and Chandragupta II

Q1. Who was Chandragupta I?

Answer: Chandragupta I was an early important ruler of the Gupta dynasty. His coins and strategic alliances helped him strengthen the kingdom and lay the foundation for a powerful empire.

Q2. Who was Chandragupta II?

Answer: Chandragupta II was a famous Gupta ruler. He was also known as Vikramaditya. During his reign, art, literature and learning flourished.

Q3. Why should Chandragupta II not be confused with Chandragupta Maurya?

Answer: Chandragupta Maurya belonged to the Maurya dynasty, while Chandragupta II belonged to the Gupta dynasty. They lived in different periods.

Q4. What does the Iron Pillar inscription tell us about Chandragupta II?

Answer: The inscription mentions a king named “Chandra”, who is identified with Chandragupta II by historians. It celebrates the king’s achievements and dedication to Vishnu.

Q5. Which god did Chandragupta II worship?

Answer: Chandragupta II was a devotee of Vishnu. Garuda, the vehicle of Vishnu, appears on many inscriptions associated with the Gupta rulers.

Q6. Why is Chandragupta II remembered?

Answer: He is remembered for his rule, support for learning and the arts, and his contribution to the prosperity of the Gupta Empire.

4. Samudragupta: The Warrior King

Q1. Who was Samudragupta?

Answer: Samudragupta was the father of Chandragupta II and one of the most powerful Gupta rulers. He fought many wars and expanded the Gupta Empire.

Q2. What is the Prayaga Prashasti?

Answer: The Prayaga Prashasti is an inscription on a pillar at Prayagraj. It describes the achievements of Samudragupta. It was written by his court poet, Harisena.

Q3. What was Samudragupta’s ambition?

Answer: According to Harisena, Samudragupta wanted to unite the Earth under his rule. The inscription describes his military campaigns and victories.

Q4. What did Samudragupta do with defeated kings?

Answer: Some defeated kings were reinstated as rulers but had to pay tribute. Other rulers submitted to him without fighting further.

Q5. How did Samudragupta support art and culture?

Answer: He supported art, learning and trade. One of his coins shows him playing the veena, which suggests his interest in music.

Q6. Why did kings record their achievements in inscriptions?

Answer: Kings used inscriptions to record their victories, achievements and religious donations. Inscriptions also helped preserve their memory for future generations and show their power to the public.

Q7. What was the Ashvamedha Yajna?

Answer: The Ashvamedha Yajna was a Vedic ritual performed by powerful kings to proclaim their supremacy. Special coins were sometimes issued to commemorate this ritual.

5. The Iron Pillar of Delhi

Q1. Where is the Iron Pillar of Delhi located?

Answer: It is located at Mehrauli in Delhi.

Q2. Who erected the Iron Pillar?

Answer: The pillar was erected during the reign of Chandragupta II. The chapter says that it may originally have stood in front of the Udayagiri caves in Madhya Pradesh.

Q3. Why is the Iron Pillar famous?

Answer: It is more than 1,600 years old and has resisted rusting for a very long time. It shows the advanced metalworking skills of ancient Indian craftsmen.

Q4. What is the weight of the Iron Pillar?

Answer: It weighs about six tonnes.

Q5. Why has the Iron Pillar not rusted easily?

Answer: Scientists believe that a thin protective layer formed on its surface because of the special iron used and its reaction with oxygen. This layer protects the iron from corrosion.

Q6. What does the Iron Pillar teach us about ancient India?

Answer: It shows that ancient Indian craftsmen had advanced knowledge of ironworking and could create strong and durable metal objects.

6. Gupta Administration and Governance

Q1. How was the Gupta Empire administered?

Answer: The Gupta Empire had a well-organised system of administration. The rulers divided the empire into provinces and gave some control to local rulers, priests and chiefs.

Q2. Why did the Guptas give land grants?

Answer: Land grants helped the rulers manage different regions and maintain relations with local leaders. Details of many grants were recorded on copper plates.

Q3. What were the main sources of revenue of the Gupta Empire?

Answer: Land tax was the main source of revenue. Other sources included fines and taxes on mines, irrigation, trade and crafts.

Q4. How was tax revenue used?

Answer: Revenue was used to run the administration, maintain the army, build temples and infrastructure, and support scholars and artists.

Q5. Which titles did Gupta rulers use?

Answer: They used titles such as Maharajadhiraja, Samrat and Chakravartin. These titles expressed their claim to supreme authority.

Q6. How did the Gupta rulers expand their empire?

Answer: They used military conquests, diplomacy and alliances. Matrimonial alliances, such as the marriage of Prabhavati Gupta into the Vakataka royal family, also helped strengthen relations.

Q7. What was the role of tributary rulers?

Answer: Tributary rulers retained their local kingdoms but accepted the Gupta ruler's supremacy and paid tribute. They could also help provide supplies for the emperor's army.

Q8. What was the importance of copper-plate inscriptions?

Answer: Copper-plate inscriptions recorded land grants and helped preserve details about grants, administration and local authority.

7. Trade and Economic Life

Q1. What was the main source of income for the Gupta rulers?

Answer: Land tax was their main source of income.

Q2. With which regions did India trade during the Gupta period?

Answer: India traded with the Mediterranean world, Southeast Asia and China.

Q3. Which goods were exported from India?

Answer: India exported textiles, spices, ivory and gemstones.

Q4. What was the importance of the Indian Ocean trade network?

Answer: It connected Indian ports with distant markets and helped merchants exchange goods with other countries.

Q5. Why was Socotra Island important for trade?

Answer: Socotra Island was an important stop on the route to Mediterranean markets. Archaeological evidence found there shows that Indian traders visited the island over many centuries.

Q6. What evidence shows that Indian traders visited Socotra?

Answer: Pottery, inscriptions in the Brahmi script and designs such as a Buddhist stupa provide evidence of Indian traders and cultural contact.

Q7. How did trade help the Gupta Empire?

Answer: Trade increased wealth and tax revenue. It also encouraged cultural exchange and helped support craftspeople, merchants, artists and scholars.

8. Faxian's Account of Indian Society

Q1. Who was Faxian?

Answer: Faxian was a Chinese Buddhist traveller who visited India in the early 5th century CE.

Q2. Why did Faxian visit India?

Answer: He came to visit Buddhist sacred places, learn from Indian scholars and collect Buddhist manuscripts to take back to China.

Q3. What did Faxian observe about life in the Gupta period?

Answer: He described many people as prosperous and happy. He also mentioned wealthy cities, orderly streets, charity houses, medical care and help for poor people.

Q4. How were poor and sick people helped according to Faxian?

Answer: Wealthy Vaishya families established houses for charity and medicines. Doctors treated the sick, and needy people received food and medicines.

Q5. What did farmers pay when they cultivated royal land?

Answer: According to Faxian, they paid a portion of their grain.

Q6. Can Faxian’s account tell us everything about Gupta society?

Answer: No. His account reflects his own observations and the people he encountered. The chapter also notes that he described the harsh treatment of Chandalas, who were considered outcastes and lived outside city limits. Historians must compare different sources before reaching conclusions.

Q7. Why do historians study more than one historical source?

Answer: Different sources provide different viewpoints. Comparing them helps historians understand the past more accurately and avoid relying on only one person's account.

9. Prabhavati Gupta and Women in Administration

Q1. Who was Prabhavati Gupta?

Answer: Prabhavati Gupta was the daughter of Chandragupta II. She married a prince of the Vakataka kingdom.

Q2. Why did Prabhavati Gupta become a ruler?

Answer: Her husband died early, so she became the regent for her kingdom while her sons were unable to rule independently.

Q3. What is a regent?

Answer: A regent is a person who governs a kingdom temporarily on behalf of a ruler who cannot yet rule or is unable to do so.

Q4. How did Prabhavati Gupta help the Guptas and Vakatakas?

Answer: She maintained strong relations between the two royal families. This helped preserve friendly political ties between the Guptas and their southern neighbours.

Q5. Which god did Prabhavati Gupta worship?

Answer: Like her father, she was a devotee of Vishnu.

Q6. What do Prabhavati Gupta’s inscriptions tell us?

Answer: They provide information about her rule, family and religious activities. One inscription calls her the “mother of two kings”, referring to her sons who later ruled the Vakataka kingdom.

Q7. What does Prabhavati Gupta’s life tell us about women in the Gupta period?

Answer: It shows that some royal women could hold political power, act as regents, make donations and support religious and cultural activities.

10. The Classical Age: Art, Literature and Learning

Q1. Why is the Gupta period called a period of creativity?

Answer: Many important works in art, architecture, literature, mathematics, astronomy and medicine were produced during this period. Peace and stability helped scholars and artists develop their ideas.

Q2. What happened to Sanskrit literature during the Gupta period?

Answer: Sanskrit literature flourished. Kalidasa became famous for his poetry and plays, and many important Puranas were compiled during this period.

Q3. Which educational institution is mentioned in the chapter?

Answer: Nalanda was an important Buddhist centre of learning. The Gupta rulers supported Buddhist institutions and monasteries.

Q4. How did peace help cultural development?

Answer: Peace gave scholars, artists and craftspeople time and resources to work. It also helped the economy grow, allowing rulers to support learning and artistic activities.

Q5. What is meant by the “classical age”?

Answer: It refers to a period remembered for important achievements in culture, literature, art, science and learning.

11. Aryabhata and Mathematics

Q1. Who was Aryabhata?

Answer: Aryabhata was an Indian mathematician and astronomer who lived around 500 CE. He lived in Kusumapura, near present-day Patna.

Q2. What is Aryabhatiya?

Answer: Aryabhatiya is a famous work on mathematics and astronomy written by Aryabhata.

Q3. What did Aryabhata explain about the Earth?

Answer: He proposed that the Earth spins on its axis, which explains the alternation of day and night.

Q4. What did Aryabhata calculate about the year?

Answer: He calculated the length of a year as 365 days, 6 hours, 12 minutes and 30 seconds, which is close to the modern value.

Q5. What did Aryabhata teach about eclipses?

Answer: He gave a correct explanation of solar and lunar eclipses.

Q6. What were Aryabhata's contributions to mathematics?

Answer: He described methods of calculation and solving equations. His work became a foundation for later mathematical and scientific progress.

Q7. Why is Aryabhata important today?

Answer: His ideas helped the development of mathematics and astronomy in India and beyond. His work shows the high level of scientific knowledge in ancient India.

12. Varahamihira and Science

Q1. Who was Varahamihira?

Answer: Varahamihira was a mathematician, astronomer and astrologer who lived in Ujjayini, an important centre of learning.

Q2. What is the Brihat Samhita?

Answer: The Brihat Samhita is Varahamihira's encyclopedic work. It covers astronomy, astrology, weather forecasting, architecture, town planning and farming.

Q3. Why is Varahamihira important in Indian science?

Answer: He combined observation, logical reasoning and traditional knowledge. His work covered many subjects and contributed to the growth of scientific learning.

Q4. What can we learn from Aryabhata and Varahamihira?

Answer: We can learn the importance of observation, logical thinking, mathematics and the study of nature.

Sample interview questions for Aryabhata

These are sample answers for the classroom activity on page 159.

Q1. What inspired you to study mathematics and astronomy?

Answer: I wanted to understand the movements of the Sun, Moon and planets and explain natural events through mathematics.

Q2. Why did you say that the Earth spins on its axis?

Answer: My study of astronomy led me to explain the alternation of day and night through the Earth's rotation.

Q3. What advice would you give students?

Answer: Study carefully, ask questions and use logical reasoning to understand the world.

Sample interview questions for Varahamihira

Q1. What subjects did you study?

Answer: I studied astronomy, astrology, weather, architecture, town planning and farming.

Q2. Why is observation important in science?

Answer: Observation helps us understand patterns in nature and develop better explanations.

Q3. How can scientific knowledge help society?

Answer: It can help people understand weather, plan towns, improve farming and solve practical problems.

13. Kalidasa and Sanskrit Literature

Q1. Who was Kalidasa?

Answer: Kalidasa was a famous Sanskrit poet and writer of the Gupta period. He is known for his beautiful poetry and literary works.

Q2. What is Meghadutam?

Answer: Meghadutam, or “The Cloud Messenger”, is a famous poem by Kalidasa. It tells the story of a yaksha who sends a message to his beloved through a passing cloud.

Q3. What does Meghadutam describe?

Answer: It describes love, separation, landscapes and weather in northern India.

Q4. Why is Kalidasa remembered?

Answer: He is remembered for his refined poetry and important contributions to Sanskrit literature.

Q5. What does Kalidasa's work tell us about Gupta culture?

Answer: It shows that literature, poetry and artistic expression flourished during the Gupta period.

14. Ayurveda and Medical Science

Q1. What is Ayurveda?

Answer: Ayurveda is a traditional Indian system of medicine. It focuses on health, the prevention of disease and treatment.

Q2. Which two important medical texts are mentioned in the chapter?

Answer: The Charaka Samhita and the Sushruta Samhita.

Q3. What subjects do these medical texts discuss?

Answer: They discuss diseases, diagnosis, treatments, diet, medicines and surgical techniques.

Q4. What does "codified" mean?

Answer: Codified means arranged and written in an organised and systematic form.

Q5. Why is the development of medical texts important?

Answer: These texts preserved medical knowledge and helped organise ideas about health, disease and treatment for future generations.

15. Gupta Art and Architecture

Q1. What were the main achievements of Gupta art?

Answer: Gupta art included beautiful sculptures, temples, cave architecture and paintings. It set high standards of artistic beauty and influenced later Indian art.

Q2. Why are the Ajanta Caves famous?

Answer: The Ajanta Caves are famous for their rock-cut architecture and paintings. Some paintings show Bodhisattvas, including Padmapani, and scenes connected with Buddhist traditions.

Q3. What is Udayagiri famous for?

Answer: Udayagiri in Madhya Pradesh is famous for rock-cut caves and intricate carvings of Hindu deities, especially Vishnu.

Q4. Why is Sarnath important in Gupta art?

Answer: Sarnath, near Varanasi in Uttar Pradesh, is known for its beautiful sculptures of Buddha.

Q5. What is shown in the Gupta-period sculptures of Ganga and Yamuna?

Answer: The sculptures show the sacred rivers as female figures. Ganga stands on a makara, a mythical creature similar to a crocodile, while Yamuna stands on a tortoise.

Q6. What does the sculpture of Vishnu on Sheshnag represent?

Answer: It represents Vishnu resting on the serpent Sheshnag, a well-known image in Hindu religious art.

Q7. What is the importance of Gupta temples and sculptures?

Answer: They show the skill of ancient Indian artists and the development of religious architecture and sculpture.

Q8. Which places are associated with important Gupta-period artistic remains?

Answer: Important places include Ajanta, Sarnath, Udayagiri and Deogarh. The chapter also shows a Gupta-era temple near Sanchi.

16. The Decline of the Gupta Empire

Q1. When did the Gupta Empire begin to decline?

Answer: The Gupta Empire began to decline in the 6th century CE.

Q2. What were the main reasons for the decline of the Gupta Empire?

Answer: Repeated attacks by the Huna tribe from Central Asia weakened the empire. Powerful regional rulers and internal conflicts also reduced Gupta control.

Q3. Who were the Hunas?

Answer: The Hunas were a group from Central Asia who repeatedly attacked the Gupta Empire.

Q4. What happened as Gupta power weakened?

Answer: Regional kingdoms became more powerful, and the Guptas lost control over large parts of northern India.

Q5. Did the decline of the Gupta Empire mean that cultural development ended?

Answer: No. Other kingdoms continued to support art, architecture, learning and religion. The Pallavas, Vakatakas and rulers of Kamarupa remained important cultural and political powers.

17. The Vakatakas, Pallavas and Kamarupa Kingdom

Q1. Who were the Vakatakas?

Answer: The Vakatakas were rulers of central parts of the Indian subcontinent. Their capital was Nandivardhana, near present-day Nagpur.

Q2. What was the relationship between the Guptas and the Vakatakas?

Answer: They were allies. The marriage of Prabhavati Gupta to a Vakataka prince helped strengthen their relationship.

Q3. Who were the Pallavas?

Answer: The Pallavas were a powerful dynasty in southern India. They ruled parts of present-day Tamil Nadu, Karnataka, Telangana and Andhra Pradesh.

Q4. What was the capital of the Pallavas?

Answer: Kanchipuram, in present-day Tamil Nadu, was their capital.

Q5. Why was Kanchipuram important?

Answer: It was a major centre of learning and was known as the “city of a thousand temples”.

Q6. What were the Pallavas known for?

Answer: They were known for supporting art and architecture. They built temples and rock-cut caves, and many were devotees of Shiva.

Q7. Where was the Kamarupa kingdom located?

Answer: It was located in the Brahmaputra Valley, broadly covering present-day Assam and parts of northern Bengal and Bangladesh.

Q8. Which dynasty ruled Kamarupa during this period?

Answer: The Varman dynasty ruled Kamarupa.

Q9. What was the ancient name of the Brahmaputra Valley in Assam?

Answer: Pragjyotisha.

Q10. What was the importance of Kamarupa?

Answer: Kamarupa was an important political and cultural centre. Temples and monasteries served as centres of learning.

18. All textbook questions and answers

These answers follow the “Questions and Activities” on pages 165–166 of the chapter PDF.

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Question 1. Complete the letter describing life in the Gupta Empire (250–300 words).

Answer:

Greetings from Pataliputra! Life here is vibrant and full of excitement. Just yesterday, I witnessed a group of traders selling colourful textiles, spices and precious stones in the market. The city is busy with merchants, craftspeople, scholars and visitors from distant lands.

The Gupta Empire is ruled by powerful kings. The rulers use armies, alliances and diplomacy to maintain their power. The empire has an organised administration, and land tax is an important source of revenue. The government uses its income to maintain the army, build temples and support public works.

Trade is flourishing. Indian merchants have trade connections with the Mediterranean world, Southeast Asia and China. Ships carry goods across the Indian Ocean. Traders bring wealth to the cities, and many markets are full of valuable goods.

Learning and culture are also developing. Sanskrit literature is flourishing, and people admire the works of poets such as Kalidasa. Scholars study mathematics, astronomy and medicine. I have heard about Aryabhata, who has made important contributions to mathematics and astronomy. The works of Varahamihira also show the importance of observing nature and studying different subjects.

Artists are creating beautiful sculptures and paintings. The Ajanta Caves are famous for their paintings, while Sarnath is known for its Buddhist sculptures. Temples and rock-cut caves show the skill of Indian craftsmen. The Iron Pillar of Delhi is another remarkable example of metalworking.

Religious traditions are also important. The Gupta rulers worship Vishnu but support Buddhist institutions as well. People can visit temples, monasteries and centres of learning.

Life in Pataliputra is full of activity. I feel fortunate to live in a period when trade, knowledge, art and literature are flourishing. I hope you will visit our city one day!

Question 2. Which Gupta ruler was also known as "Vikramaditya"?

Answer: Chandragupta II was also known as Vikramaditya.

Question 3. "Periods of peace support the development of sociocultural life, literature, science and technology." Explain this statement with reference to the Gupta Empire.

Answer:

Peace and stability during the Gupta period helped society and culture develop. When there was less conflict, scholars and artists could concentrate on their work. The economy also became stronger, allowing rulers to support learning and artistic activities.

Sanskrit literature flourished, and Kalidasa became famous for his poetry. Aryabhata made important contributions to mathematics and astronomy. Varahamihira studied astronomy, weather, architecture and farming. Medical knowledge was organised in important texts such as the Charaka Samhita and the Sushruta Samhita.

Art and architecture also developed. The Ajanta Caves became famous for their paintings, while Sarnath became known for its Buddhist sculptures. The Iron Pillar of Delhi shows the advanced metallurgical skills of the period.

Trade with distant regions brought wealth and encouraged cultural exchange. Thus, peace and stability helped the Gupta Empire make important contributions to literature, science, technology, art and architecture.

Question 4. Recreate a scene from a Gupta ruler's court. Write a short script for a role-play.

Answer: A Scene in the Court of Chandragupta II

Characters: King Chandragupta II, Minister, Scholar, Poet and Merchant.

King: Welcome to my court. Tell me how our kingdom can become more prosperous.

Minister: Your Majesty, we should improve administration, collect taxes fairly and maintain peace throughout the kingdom.

Merchant: Your Majesty, trade is growing. Better roads and safe trade routes will help merchants bring more wealth to the kingdom.

Scholar: Your Majesty, education and learning are important. We should support scholars and centres of learning.

Poet: I would also like to present a poem in Sanskrit to celebrate the beauty of our land.

King: Excellent! A strong kingdom needs good administration, trade, education and art. We shall support all these activities.

Minister: Your Majesty, your support will help our kingdom prosper.

King: Let our kingdom become famous for knowledge, justice and creativity!

All characters bow to the king.

Question 5. Match the two columns.

Column A	Correct answer
1. Kanchipuram	(d) Known as a city of a thousand temples
2. Ujjayini	(e) A prominent centre of learning in ancient India
3. Udayagiri	(b) Famous for rock-cut caves featuring intricate carvings of Hindu deities, especially Vishnu
4. Ajanta	(a) Known for vibrant cave paintings that depict the Jataka tales
5. Pataliputra	(c) Capital of the Guptas

Question 6. Who were the Pallavas and where did they rule?

Answer: The Pallavas were a powerful dynasty of southern India. They ruled parts of present-day Tamil Nadu, Karnataka, Telangana and Andhra Pradesh. Their capital was Kanchipuram, which was an important centre of learning. The Pallavas supported art and architecture and built temples and rock-cut caves.

Question 7. Visit a nearby historical site, museum or heritage building and write a report.

Sample answer: A Visit to a Historical Site

Model report — replace the details with those of the place you actually visit.

Title: Report on a Visit to a Historical Site

Our school organised an educational visit to a historical site. The purpose of the visit was to understand our history and learn about ancient architecture and culture.

During the visit, we observed the building's design, carvings, sculptures and other historical features. Our teacher explained the importance of preserving monuments and protecting our cultural heritage. We also learned how historians study inscriptions, coins, paintings and other objects to understand the past.

The architecture showed the artistic skills of the people who built the structure. The guide explained the history of the site and shared interesting facts about the people and rulers associated with it.

The visit was enjoyable and educational. It helped us understand history better than reading about it only in a textbook. We learned that historical monuments are valuable sources of information about earlier societies. We should protect these places for future generations.

19. Additional important exam questions

Very short-answer questions (1 mark)

Q1. What was the capital of the Gupta Empire?

Answer: Pataliputra.

Q2. Who wrote the Prayaga Prashasti?

Answer: Harisena.

Q3. Which Gupta ruler was called Vikramaditya?

Answer: Chandragupta II.

Q4. Who was the father of Chandragupta II?

Answer: Samudragupta.

Q5. Who was the Chinese traveller who visited India during the Gupta period?

Answer: Faxian.

Q6. Who wrote Aryabhatiya?

Answer: Aryabhata.

Q7. Who wrote Meghadutam?

Answer: Kalidasa.

Q8. What was the main source of revenue for the Guptas?

Answer: Land tax.

Q9. Which dynasty ruled Kamarupa?

Answer: The Varman dynasty.

Q10. What was the capital of the Pallavas?

Answer: Kanchipuram.

Q11. Which island is mentioned as an important stop on the route to Mediterranean markets?

Answer: Socotra Island.

Q12. What is the name of Varahamihira's famous work?

Answer: Brihat Samhita.

Short-answer questions (2–3 marks)

Q1. Mention three achievements of the Gupta period.

Answer: Sanskrit literature flourished, mathematics and astronomy advanced, and beautiful sculptures, paintings and temples were created.

Q2. Why is the Iron Pillar of Delhi important?

Answer: It is more than 1,600 years old and has resisted rusting for a long time. It shows the advanced metalworking skills of ancient India.

Q3. What were the main sources of Gupta revenue?

Answer: Land tax was the main source. Other sources included fines and taxes on mines, irrigation, trade and crafts.

Q4. How did the Gupta rulers maintain political relations with other kingdoms?

Answer: They used military campaigns, diplomacy and matrimonial alliances. Some defeated kings retained their kingdoms but paid tribute.

Q5. What did Faxian tell us about Gupta society?

Answer: He described prosperous cities, charity houses, medical care and orderly streets. He also recorded the harsh treatment of Chandalas, showing that society was not equally prosperous for everyone.

Q6. What was Prabhavati Gupta's contribution?

Answer: She acted as regent of the Vakataka kingdom and maintained strong relations between the Vakatakas and the Guptas.

Q7. What were the contributions of Aryabhata?

Answer: Aryabhata wrote Aryabhatiya, studied planetary movements, explained day and night through the Earth's rotation, and gave explanations of solar and lunar eclipses.

Q8. How did the Gupta rulers support religion and learning?

Answer: They supported their own religious traditions and also patronised Buddhist institutions, including Nalanda and Buddhist monasteries.

Long-answer questions (4–5 marks)

Q1. Explain the main achievements of the Gupta period.

Answer: The Gupta period was an important age in Indian history. Sanskrit literature flourished, and Kalidasa became a famous poet. Aryabhata and Varahamihira made important contributions to mathematics, astronomy and other fields of knowledge. Medical texts were organised and refined. Art and architecture developed, as seen in the Ajanta Caves, Sarnath sculptures and Udayagiri carvings. The Iron Pillar of Delhi shows advanced metalworking skills. Trade with distant regions increased wealth and cultural exchange. These achievements are why the period is sometimes called the Classical Age.

Q2. Describe the administration and economy of the Gupta Empire.

Answer: The Gupta Empire had an organised administration. The rulers divided the empire into provinces and gave some control to local rulers, priests and chiefs. Land grants were recorded on copper plates. The main source of revenue was land tax, while fines and taxes on mines,

irrigation, trade and crafts provided additional income. The revenue supported the army, administration, temples, infrastructure, scholars and artists. Trade with the Mediterranean world, Southeast Asia and China brought wealth to the empire.

Q3. Explain the contributions of Aryabhata, Varahamihira and Kalidasa.

Answer: Aryabhata contributed to mathematics and astronomy. He wrote Aryabhatiya, studied planetary movements and explained the Earth's rotation as the cause of day and night. Varahamihira wrote Brihat Samhita, which covered astronomy, weather, architecture, town planning and farming. Kalidasa was a famous Sanskrit poet. His work Meghadutam describes love, landscapes and weather. These three figures show the importance of learning and creativity during the Gupta period.

Q4. Describe the reasons for the decline of the Gupta Empire.

Answer: The Gupta Empire began to decline in the 6th century CE. Repeated attacks by the Hunas from Central Asia weakened its control over northern India. Internal conflicts and the rise of powerful regional rulers also reduced Gupta power. As the empire weakened, other dynasties such as the Pallavas and Vakatakas became important in their regions. However, cultural and intellectual activities continued in different parts of the subcontinent.

20. Quick revision table

Topic	Important fact
Gupta capital	Pataliputra
Chandragupta II	Also known as Vikramaditya
Samudragupta	Known for military campaigns
Prayaga Prashasti	Written by Harisena
Iron Pillar	Shows advanced metalworking
Main source of revenue	Land tax
Faxian	Chinese Buddhist traveller
Prabhavati Gupta	Regent of the Vakataka kingdom
Aryabhata	Mathematician and astronomer
Varahamihira	Author of Brihat Samhita
Kalidasa	Famous Sanskrit poet
Meghadutam	Poem by Kalidasa
Ajanta	Famous for cave paintings
Udayagiri	Famous for rock-cut caves and carvings
Pallava capital	Kanchipuram
Kamarupa	Ruled by the Varman dynasty
Decline of the Guptas	Hunas, internal conflicts and rising regional powers

Exam preparation tip: Learn the important names, books, places, inscriptions and achievements first. Then practise the textbook answers and the four long-answer questions. Write in short, clear sentences and use examples from the chapter wherever possible.